

Early Gothic

While the innovations at the choir of Saint-Denis spread quickly in Europe, some countries embraced them more readily than others. Germany was initially cautious. France was ambitious and enthusiastic, applying Gothic mainly to religious buildings. One of the first ribbed vaults after Saint-Denis was the nave of Saint-Étienne at Caen in the 1120s (although it was preceded by Durham Cathedral in England, opposite, in c.1090).

With the rediscovery of Euclidian geometry in the early 12th century, early Gothic cathedrals achieved a spatial unity and harmony, the style developing partly through a revival of mathematics and science and partly on time-honoured intuition. What constituted drawings and plans at that time became more accurate – as, consequently, did construction. Flying buttresses countered the outward thrust from the high ceiling and walls, and rounded arches gave way to lancet (pointed) arches, which held greater loads and also laid emphasis on a religious sense of Heaven-directed yearning.

